The Vistula River

The Vistula is the longest river in Poland, flowing for just over one thousand kilometres from its source on Barania Góra in the Silesian Beskids to the Gdańsk Bay of the Baltic Sea. Its drainage basin covers more than half of the territory of Poland.

Along its course the river passes many historic cities, including Kraków, Sandomierz, Warsaw, Płock, Toruń and Grudziądz. In Kraków it flows beneath Wawel Hill, the seat of Polish kings for centuries, while in Warsaw it separates the Old Town from the district of Praga.

For hundreds of years the Vistula was a major trade route. Grain from the fertile lands of the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth was floated downstream to Gdańsk and shipped to Amsterdam and other ports of Western Europe, which brought great wealth to merchants and the nobility.

Today large stretches of the river remain relatively natural, with sandbanks and islands that provide habi-

tats for birds such as terns and little ringed plovers. Many sections are protected within the European Union's Natura 2000 network. Floods remain a serious risk: the catastrophic flood of May and June 2010 affe-cted towns along the middle and lower Vistula.